

Panic Attacks & Panic Disorder

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What are the symptoms of a panic attack?

A panic attack happens suddenly. Symptoms usually peak within 10 minutes after it starts and then disappear soon after. Physical symptoms of a panic attack include:

You may feel:

Panic attacks are very unpleasant and can be frightening. If you've had symptoms of a panic attack, it's important to see a healthcare provider. They can give you an official diagnosis and ensure there's no underlying physical cause.

How long can a panic attack last?

Panic attacks usually last 5 to 20 minutes. But some people have reported attacks lasting up to an hour.

What causes panic attacks?

Experts don't know exactly why some people experience panic attacks or develop panic disorder. Your [brain](#) and [nervous system](#) play key roles in how you perceive and handle fear and anxiety. Researchers think that dysfunction of your [amygdala](#) — the part of your brain that processes fear and other emotions — may be at the root of these conditions. They also think chemical imbalances in [gamma-aminobutyric acid \(GABA\)](#), [cortisol](#) and [serotonin](#) may play a large role.

Your risk of having panic disorder increases if you have:

What triggers panic attacks?

There's often no specific trigger for panic attacks. But people who have a phobia can experience phobia-related triggers that lead to a panic attack. For example, someone with [trypanophobia](#) (intense fear of needles) may experience a panic attack if they have to get their blood drawn for a medical test. For some people, the fear of having a panic attack is often enough to trigger one.

It's important to note that one of the criteria for panic disorder is that the panic attacks don't have a known trigger.